BOOKS

# REALITY CHECK

**Sujit Saraf's new novel, *Island*, chronicles a dystopian attempt to evangelise the inhabitants of North Sentinel Island**

**So much of what goes on in the Andaman & Nicobar Islands** feels novelistic that it shouldn't be surprising when a novel set there leans particularly heavily on actual events and characters.

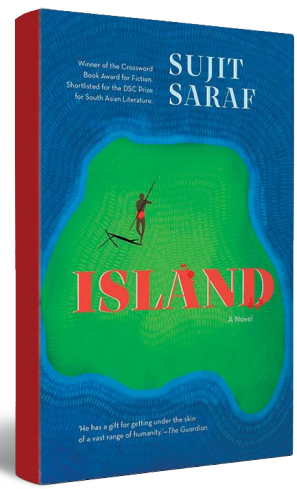
In *Island* we have Steven Li, an American adventurer-missionary who for years has been preparing to go to North Sentinel Island to make Christians of one of the last isolated populations in the world. In Port Blair he recruits Nirmal Chandra Mattoo, a 'fallen' anthropologist.

Mattoo, whose point of view we follow for most of the novel, is inspired by Verrier Elwin and was once a rising star. He is an expert on the Jarawa and the Sentinelese, both classified in island officialese as a Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group (PVTG). He used to be much in demand on the 'contact missions' carried out by the Anthropological Survey of India, but was cancelled after he took the contact part too far on a mission to North Sentinel. The novel finds him reduced to running a shop selling counterfeit tribal artifacts to tourists. That is, until the arrival of Li gives him another chance to visit the island.

It is clear that a lot of research has gone into the writing of *Island*. Particularly brave are the sections that use what is known of other tribes to imagine life on North Sentinel. The book provides a good deal of history as background and travels over much more of the Andamans than most fiction set there. But those who know the islands well might pause at some of the details or find missing the distinctive texture of life there. The novel's characters don't run particularly deep; their actions at times feel too conveniently motivated, and their dialogue occasionally seems intended to educate the reader. *Island* does succeed in being a quick, informative and engaging read.



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**ISLAND: A Novel**
*By Sujit Saraf*
SPEAKING TIGER
**₹499; 256** pages

At the heart of *Island* are questions about why civilisations feel the need to impose themselves on others, about how a state is to deal with people who do not—cannot—recognise its control over them. Administrators in the islands since British times have tried various strategies, with the result that entire populations have been driven to extinction or to a dependent existence. The hostility of the Sentinelse to outsiders and their being isolated have protected them until now.

Even accepting that the treatment of various PVTGs in the islands has often been ignorant, thoughtless or self-serving, the fate of the Sentinelese at the end of *Island* is a particularly cynical one. It also feels contrived by the need for a spectacular conclusion. A similar situation came about in reality a few years ago, and we know it ended without catastrophe. In that light, maybe the novel can be read as a warning about what could happen when the worst impulses of the state take over. ■

**–Srinath Perur**